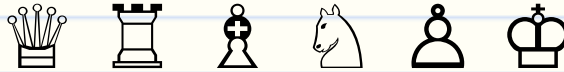


IMPERIUM

The Official Unofficial Hand Manual

(its like chess but with more stuff and also less stuff??)



written and drawn by someone who should definitely be doing homework right now

version 2.0 — i fixed SO many bugs you have no idea

⚠ DO NOT LOSE THIS MANUAL ⚠

it took me like 4 hours and my hand hurts

100% HAND DRAWN*

**not actually hand drawn i used a computer but whatever*

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(yes there's a table of contents, this is a REAL manual ok)

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ps: page numbers might be wrong i didn't count

FUN FACT: The word "Imperator" is Latin for "commander" which is WAY cooler than "king" imo. The Romans knew what was up.

1. What even IS Imperium??

OK so Imperium is a strategy board game that I ~~completely~~ invented from scratch with ~~no inspiration whatsoever~~ came up with totally organically. It's played on an 8x8 board like chess but the pieces are WAY different and there's this sick command ability thing that chess WISHES it had.

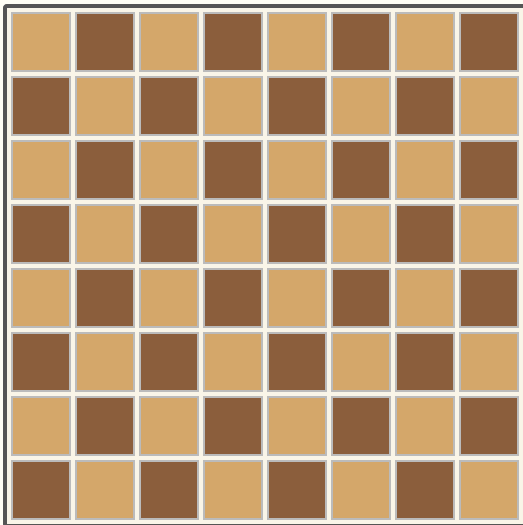
Two players: White and Black. White goes first (sorry that's just how it is, don't @ me).

The whole point is to capture the other guy's **Imperator** or trap them so they literally can't do anything.

WARNING: In chess, if you can't move it's a DRAW (stalemate). In Imperium, if you can't move, you LOSE. So don't get trapped lol.

2. The Board

It's 8 by 8 squares. Light and dark alternating. Just like chess. You know what a chessboard looks like come on.



^ see?? 8x8. not that hard. i counted twice to make sure

* rows are called "ranks" and columns are "files" but honestly it doesn't matter just call them rows and columns like a normal person

FUN FACT: The board has 64 squares total. That's the same as chess, checkers, and that one game your grandma plays on her phone. Coincidence?? (yes)

3. The Pieces

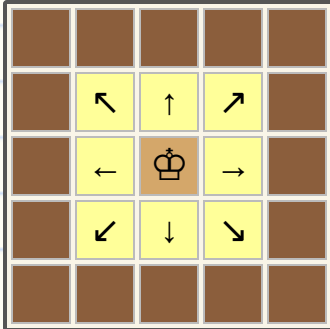
OK this is the big part. There are 6 types of pieces. Each player gets 16 total. Here we go:

(continued from last page because i talk too much)



Imperator

The KING basically. Moves 1 square in ANY direction (up down left right diagonal). **CANNOT** move into check!! This is the piece you need to protect. If this dies you lose. **NO PRESSURE**



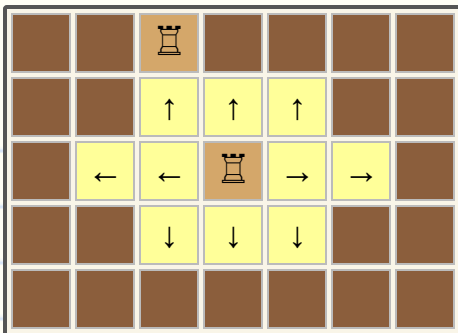
yellow = where it can go (8 squares max)

IMPORTANT: The Imperator is the **MOST** important piece. If it gets captured, game over. You **LOSE**. Doesn't matter if you have 15 other pieces. Done. Finito. Bye.



Legate

It's a ROOK ok?? Moves in straight lines (up/down/left/right) as far as it wants. Can't jump over stuff. Super powerful, don't waste it. **i always lose mine early lol**



goes in straight lines, stops when it hits something

PRO TIP: Don't move your Legate out too early! It's like the second most powerful piece. Wait until the board opens up. (says the person who always moves it out immediately)

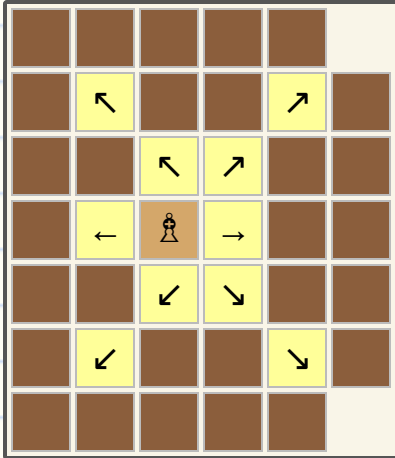


Tribune

It's a BISHOP. Moves diagonally as far as it wants. Also can't jump over stuff.

Stays on the same color square forever which is kinda weird but whatever.

light tribune on light squares, dark on dark, they NEVER switch



diagonal lines only, as far as it wants

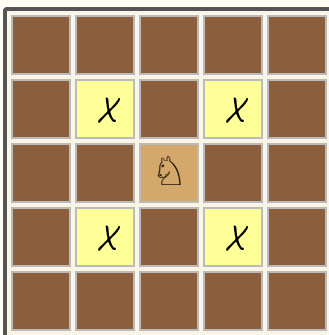


Eques

KNIGHT. The L-shape one. Moves 2 squares one way and 1 square the other way.

CAN jump over pieces which makes it really annoying to deal with.

literally the worst piece to play against imo



8 possible spots — can jump over pieces!! this is a big deal

FUN FACT: The Eques is the ONLY piece that can jump over other pieces. Every other piece gets blocked. Knights in chess do this too but the Eques sounds cooler so there.

i drew these diagrams myself btw

you're welcome



Signifer

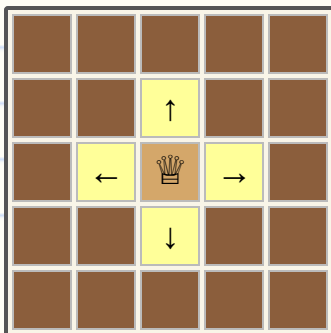


OK this one is **WEIRD**. It has **TWO** things it can do (you pick one each turn):

Option A: Move 1 square up/down/left/right (just 1, not diagonal!!)

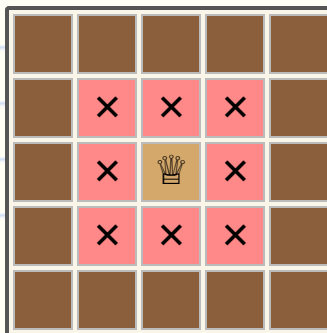
Option B: **REMOVE** an adjacent enemy piece **WITHOUT MOVING!!** Like it just kills something next to it. The Signifer stays right where it is. Yeah. Read that again if you need to.

Option A - Move:



yellow = move (orthogonal only)

Option B - Remove:



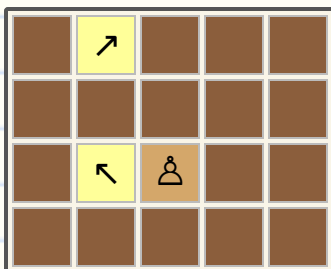
red = can **REMOVE** enemies here
(all 8 adjacent squares!!)

WARNING: This is the **only** piece that can eliminate another piece without moving to its square. It's **SUPER** powerful, don't underestimate it!! Also: removing an enemy might accidentally expose your Emperor to attack, so be careful. The game won't let you do it if it would put you in check though so don't worry too much.



Milites

Moves 1 square diagonally **FORWARD** (toward the enemy). That's it. (Like a pawn that **ONLY** captures. But it can capture **OR** move to an empty square, both diagonally forward. When it reaches the other end, it **PROMOTES** (see page 7).



only forward diagonal (2 squares max)

white goes UP, black goes DOWN. they zigzag forward like little drunk soldiers lol

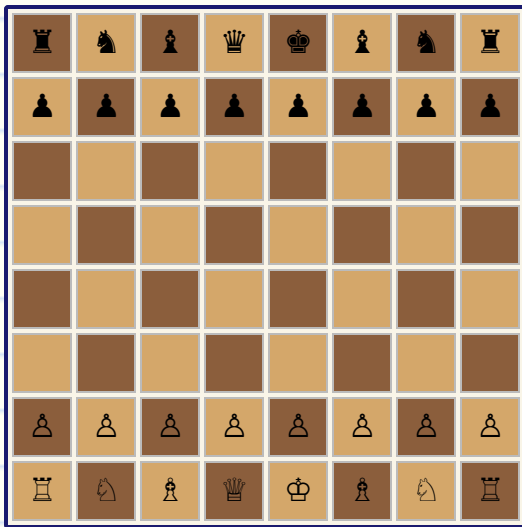
4. Starting Position

White on bottom (rows 6-7), Black on top (rows 0-1). Same setup for both sides, like chess but the pieces have different names.

Back Rank (from left to right):

Legate • Eques • Tribune • Signifer • Imperator • Tribune • Eques • Legate

then 8 Milites in front of them



black on top, white on bottom. each side = 16 pieces (8 back row + 8 milites)

5. How Turns Work

1. Click one of YOUR pieces
2. The game shows you where it can move (green highlighted squares)
3. Click a highlighted square to move there
4. Your turn ends (unless you use Emperor Command, see next page!)

If you click a piece and it has NO valid moves, nothing happens. **this is normal not a bug** (ok maybe it's a bug but whatever)

PRO TIP: You can click a different piece to change your selection. Click an empty square to deselect.

Pretty standard stuff.

IMPORTANT: CHECK: If your Emperor is being attacked (in "check"), you **MUST** get it out of check on your turn. You can: move the Emperor, block the attack, or capture the attacker. If you can't do any of those, you lose!

6. Emperor Command ★

OK SO THIS IS THE COOLEST MECHANIC IN THE GAME and i will fight anyone who disagrees.

After you make your normal move, if there are any friendly pieces next to your Emperor, a popup will ask if you want to use **Emperor Command**. This lets you give **one extra move** to a friendly piece sitting next to your Emperor.

How it works:

1. You make your normal move
2. A popup asks "Use Command?"
3. Click YES → all pieces next to your Emperor light up **purple**
4. Click one of them → its valid moves show up in green
5. Click where to move it → BAM, extra move done
6. Turn ends

FUN FACT: This is basically like having a bonus action in D&D. Your Emperor is like "hey go do something else real quick" and the piece is like "ok boss." I think that's really cool.

Rules:

- Only **ONCE** per turn (not per game, per **TURN**)
- The piece must be **adjacent** to your Emperor (any of the 8 surrounding squares, including diagonal)
- You **CANNOT** command the Emperor itself (that would be weird)
- The extra move follows all normal rules (can't move into check, etc.)
- If **NO** pieces are next to your Emperor, the option doesn't appear

PRO TIP: The command move happens **BEFORE** the turn switches. So if your normal move puts the enemy in check, and then you use the command to do something else, the enemy **STILL** has to deal with the check on their turn. Pretty sneaky right??

7. Signifer – the weird one (more detail)

When you click your Signifer, a popup asks you to choose:

- "Move (1 orthogonal)" → shows normal move options in green (up/down/left/right, 1 square)
- "Remove adjacent enemy" → shows removable enemies in red. Click one to delete it. Signifer stays put.

WARNING: If a square has both options (enemy is orthogonally adjacent), the popup handles it. You don't have to worry about it. The game is smarter than it looks. (which admittedly isn't saying much)

8. Milites Promotion

When your Milites reaches the other end of the board (the "back rank"), it **PROMOTES!**

A popup lets you pick what it becomes:

-  **Imperator** – risky!! You'd have 2 Imperators. If **EITHER** gets captured, you lose!
-  **Legate** – always a solid choice
-  **Tribune** – good for diagonal control
-  **Eques** – knights are always useful
-  **Signifer** – another signifer?? chaos ensues
-  **Stay Milites** – why would you do this lol

WARNING: Promoting to Imperator is **EXTREMELY** risky. Yes, having 2 Imperators sounds cool, but the enemy only needs to capture **ONE** of them to win. Think of it like having two hearts – cool until someone stabs either one and you die anyway. Your call.

FUN FACT: In chess, pawns can only promote to queen/rook/bishop/knight (not king). In Imperium, you **CAN** promote to Imperator because we live dangerously here.

9. Winning (or losing lol)

There are exactly **TWO** ways to win. That's it. No draws. No ties. No "let's call it even."

Way 1: Capture

Capture the enemy Imperator. ★

This is the most common way. Protect your Imperator, go after theirs. Simple. (simple to understand, hard to actually do)

Way 2: Stalemate

Trap them so they have **NO** legal moves.

If it's their turn and they literally cannot do **ANYTHING**, they lose. In chess this is a draw.

Here it's a **WIN** for you. **haha get wrecked**

10. Things I Forgot to Mention

- **Undo:** There's an Undo button. It undoes **ONE** move. That's it. One. Not two. Not unlimited. One. Use it wisely.

- *New Game:* Click "New Game" to reset everything. All pieces go back. All your mistakes are erased. A fresh start. Unlike real life.
- *Check display:* If your Emperor is in check, it gets a red glow. Pay attention to that!!
- *Last move highlight:* The squares from the last move are highlighted so you can see what just happened (in case you weren't paying attention which is fair)

the undo only saves one state so if you use Emperor Command and then undo, it undoes the COMMAND, not the whole turn. i think. honestly i forget how i coded it.

11. Strategy Tips

from a grandmaster from someone who loses a LOT

PRO TIP: Keep pieces between your Emperor and enemy long-range pieces (Legates and Tribunes) because they will *SNIPES* your Emperor from across the board. It's not even funny how fast you can lose.

PRO TIP: The Signifer is incredibly powerful if you use it right. Position it next to high-value enemy pieces and just... delete them. Without moving. While sipping tea. While your opponent watches in horror.

PRO TIP: Use Emperor Command **AGGRESSIVELY**. An extra move per turn is **HUGE**. Try to keep pieces near your Emperor so you always have the option. But also don't bunch them up too much or they'll all get captured in one area lol.

PRO TIP: Don't forget Milites promotion! Push them forward when you can. Even one promotion can turn the game around. A free Legate or Tribune from a pawn? Yes please.

WARNING: Don't promote to Emperor unless you're **REALLY** sure you can protect both of them. I've done it twice and lost both times. Learn from my mistakes. (or don't, i'm not your mom)

FUN FACT: The Eques (knight) is great for annoying your opponent because it can jump over pieces. Send it behind enemy lines early and cause chaos. It's like the fly that won't leave you alone at a picnic.

12. FAQ (questions nobody asked)

Q: Can the Signifer remove a piece that's protecting the enemy Emperor?

A: YES! And it's one of the best moves in the game. Remove the defender, then go after the Emperor next turn. Evil laugh optional.

Q: What if both Emperors are captured at the same time??

A: That literally can't happen. Only one player moves at a time. Did you even read the rules??

Q: Can I use Imperator Command on a piece that was just moved?

A: YES! The command can be used on any adjacent friendly piece (except the Imperator). Even if you just moved that piece with your normal move. That's the whole point!

Q: Is this game balanced?

A: Absolutely, I carefully playtested each piece. Probably not. I made it up. If something's broken, just house-rule it. That's what the Romans would have done.

Q: Why is it called Imperium?

A: Because "Chess But Different" is a terrible name and "Imperium" sounds cool and roman and stuff. Also I already made the HTML file with that name so it's too late to change it.

Q: Can Milites move backward?

A: NO. Forward diagonal only. They're soldiers, not cowards. ok that was mean sorry milites

if you have more questions, figure it out yourself. i already spent 4 hours on this manual and my hand literally hurts from typing. bye.

IMPERIUM

that's it, go play!

if you find bugs, that's a feature not a bug

if you find features, that's a bug not a feature

honestly i can't tell anymore



IMPERIUM © some kid who was supposed to be studying

please don't sue me i don't have any money

now 100% more goofy!